for debate, a more open and critical press, and greater political participation. Yet their position differs from that of U.S. critics of Cuba in several significant ways. First, they argue that if Cuba has not developed these aspects of democracy, it is precisely *because* of U.S. threats. “The unanimity present in the Cuban media is the reflection of a *siege mentality* conditioned by U.S. pressures, which work against greater pluralism and a broader public debate,” argues a Cuban media critic.[45] “Some of the intolerance that you see in Cuba toward the dissenters against the system has to do with the perception that these dissenters are allied with a powerful foreign country,” explains another Cuban intellectual. “We are dealing with an undeclared war that the United States is waging against us. So obviously you don’t get the kind of tolerant environment you might find in Switzerland … A relaxation of the way that dissenters against the system are perceived would require a relaxation in the international environment so that we could accommodate dissenting views against the system in a different way.”[46]

Moreover, Cuban critics tend to draw a clear distinction between the issue of political openness, debate, and participation, and the idea of a multi-party system. While they see limitations on the former as the unfortunate result of historical and international factors, the absence of the latter is not seen with regret. “On many occasions multi-party systems are identified with pluralism. But that is not necessarily the case; sometimes multi-party systems are precisely the way to *deny* pluralism. In Cuba during the 1900s, we had plenty of political parties but no democracy. For us, the multi-party system consistently denied the possibility of an alternative road for the country,” explains Juan Antonio Blanco.[47] Luis Suárez Salazar argues that “actually existing democracy” in Latin America and the Caribbean is a “democracy of ‘apartheid.’ ” “The contribution of a popular democracy is to construct a representative system in a different manner than the liberal bourgeois democracies do. Our representative system does not have to be constructed on the basis of a multi-party system that has historically been a failure in Cuba.” Nonetheless, Suárez is critical of the limitations on popular mobilization and participation in Cuba, and calls especially